



ANCHORITE
VERSE

ISSUE
07

\$5.99



RENN
SLOANE
BIX
ECHO

MOTHER BATHYAL

IN THE DEPTHS, SHE DREAMS.





ANOTHER
DEAD END.
SURPRISE.

NOT DEAD.
JUST... SEALED.
BY DESIGN.

I... I THINK
I SEE A PRESSURE
VALVE, BUT IT'S
ON THE OTHER
SIDE OF THAT
WALL.

THEN WE
GO AROUND.

SOMETHING
FOLLOWS.
NOT CLOSE.
NOT YET.

BUT CLOSE
ENOUGH TO
STIR THE SILT
BEHIND US.



RENN.
FOCUS.



I AM
FOCUSED.

FOCUSED ON
NOT GETTING
EATEN.



DO YOU
THINK IT EATS
METAL?

OR JUST...
PEOPLE?



WE DON'T
NEED TO KNOW.

WE JUST NEED
TO MOVE.

WAVES IN THE SILT.
NOT WATER.
PRESENCE.

PATIENT.

DELIBERATE.
HUNGRY.



THE PASSAGE
NARROWS.

THE AIR
THICKENS.

THE SILENCE
LISTENS.



SHP
SHP



IT KNOWS
WE ARE
HERE.

AND IT
WAITS.

DEPTHS BELOW. SECRETS OLDER.
WE GO DOWN.
IT COMES AFTER.

ROUNDING
THE WESTERN
PASSAGE...

...WE FOUND
OUR PATH
BLOCKED.

A WALL OF
GOLDEN SILT.
UNNATURALLY
THICK. UNNATURALLY
STILL.

HALT.

RENN.

THAT'S
NOT NATURAL.

SLOANE.

NO CURRENT.
NO SOURCE.
JUST... THERE.

BIX.

I-IT'S TOO
THICK... HOW IS
IT EVEN—

ECHO.

SOMETHING
HOLDS IT
IN PLACE.

WHATEVER'S
BEYOND THAT
ARCH...

IT'S BIG.

THE ARCHWAY
DARKENED...
AS THOUGH
SOMETHING VAST
WAS SETTLING
INTO PLACE JUST
BEYOND IT.



CHILDREN
OF THE
PRESSURE.

YOU HAVE
COME FAR.



...
MOTHER
BATHYAL.



MOTHER
BATHYAL

SOVEREIGN OF THE
DROWNED THRONE



WE DID NOT
SEEK AUDIENCE.

WE SEEK
PASSAGE.



HEH.

EVERYONE
SEEKS
SOMETHIN'.



S-SHE'S
BEAUTIFUL...

AND
TERRIFYING...



BEAUTY IS
NOT MERCY.

TERROR IS
NOT CRUELTY.

I AM THE
PRESSURE
THAT REMEMBERS.



YOU MAY
WALK BENEATH
MY SEA.

IF YOU DO NOT
FORGET WHO
YOU ARE.



IN THE DEPTHS, MEMORY IS THE ONLY COMPASS.



金風集



I AM
MOTHER BATHYAL.

I DO NOT
BREATHE AS YOU
DO. NEITHER DOES
THIS PLACE.

HERE, WE
SWIM IN PRESSURE.
WE DRINK GOLDEN
ATMOSPHERE.

YOU ARE
NOT THE FIRST
SURFACE-CHILDREN
TO DESCEND.

YOU WILL
NOT BE THE LAST.



I DO NOT
KEEP YOU HERE
AGAINST YOUR WILL.

IF YOU WISH
TO LEAVE, THE DOOR
BEHIND YOU IS
UNLOCKED.

BUT KNOW THIS—

THOSE WHO
TURN BACK AFTER
TOUCHING DEPTH...

ARE NEVER
THE SAME.



WE DIDN'T
COME THIS FAR
TO TURN BACK.

TELL US WHAT
YOU KNOW.



RENN

WATCHES LIKE A COILED
SPRING. READY TO MOVE.



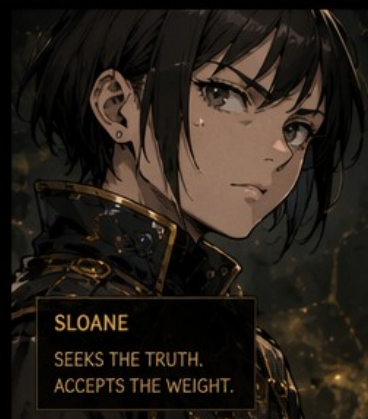
ECHO

LISTENS TO WHAT
WORDS CANNOT REACH.



BIX

WANTS TO UNDERSTAND.
FEARS HE WON'T.



SLOANE

SEEKS THE TRUTH.
ACCEPTS THE WEIGHT.



THERE ARE
THINGS IN THIS
WORLD THAT SLEEP
BENEATH THE HULL
OF REALITY.

IF YOU ARE
WISE, YOU WILL
CHOOSE WHICH
ONES TO WAKE.



MOTHER BATHYAL
SHE WHO BREATHES
THE GOLDEN DEEP.
SHE WHOSE VEIL
HIDES ALL.

YOU TRESPASS
IN A PRESSURE
THAT DOES NOT
FORGIVE.

I OFFER YOU
THIS MERCY.



RENN
SLOANE
BIX
ECHO
—?!



THE IMPLOSION IS
NOT VIOLENT.
IT IS CERTAIN.
PRESSURE MADE
MANIFEST.



...UNGH.



W-WHAT
WAS
THAT?!



SHE
THREW
NOTHIN'...

...AND IT
HIT LIKE
EVERYTHING.



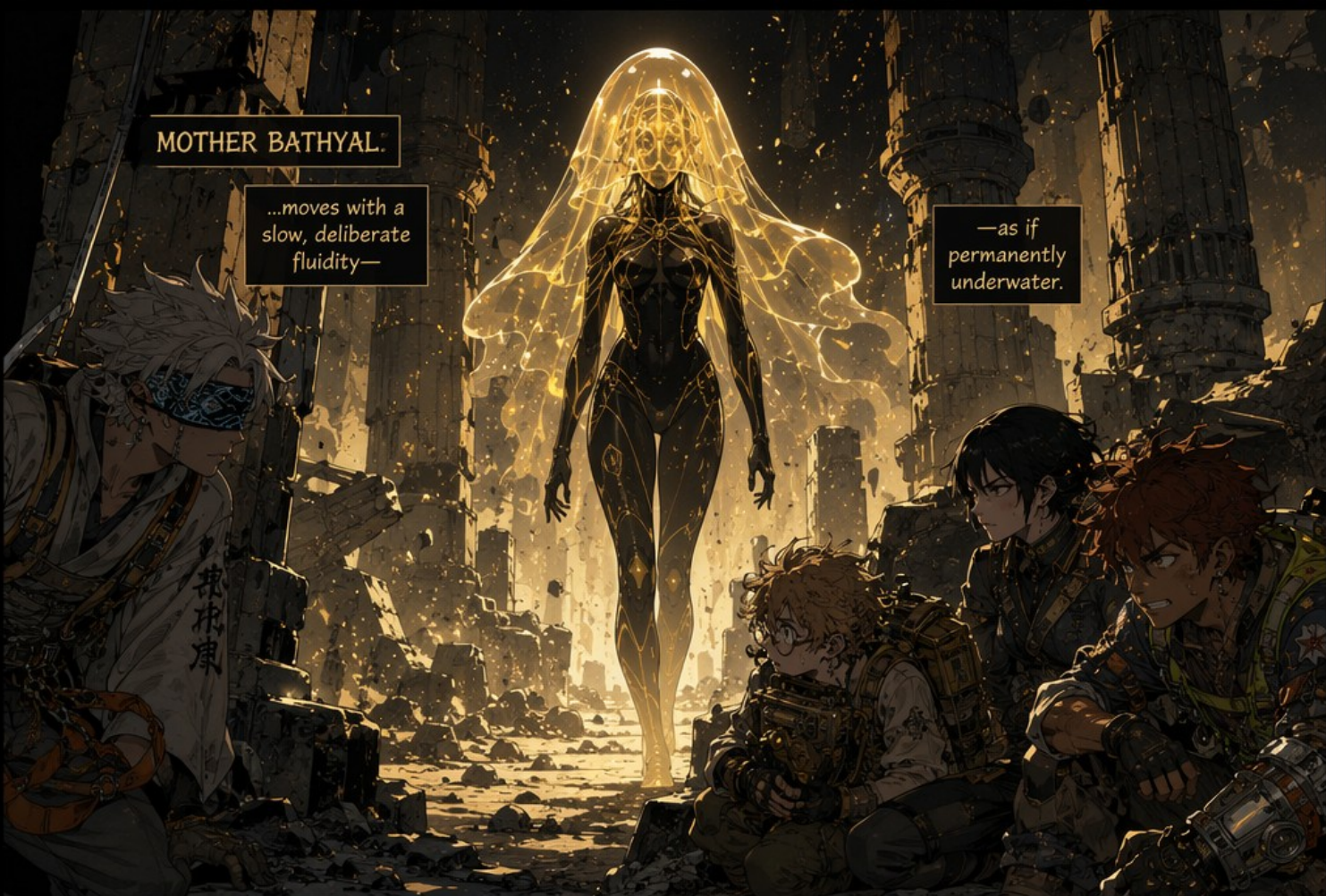
AN
INVISIBLE
WEIGHT.

FOCUSED.
PRECISE.

MOTHER BATHYAL.

...moves with a
slow, deliberate
fluidity—

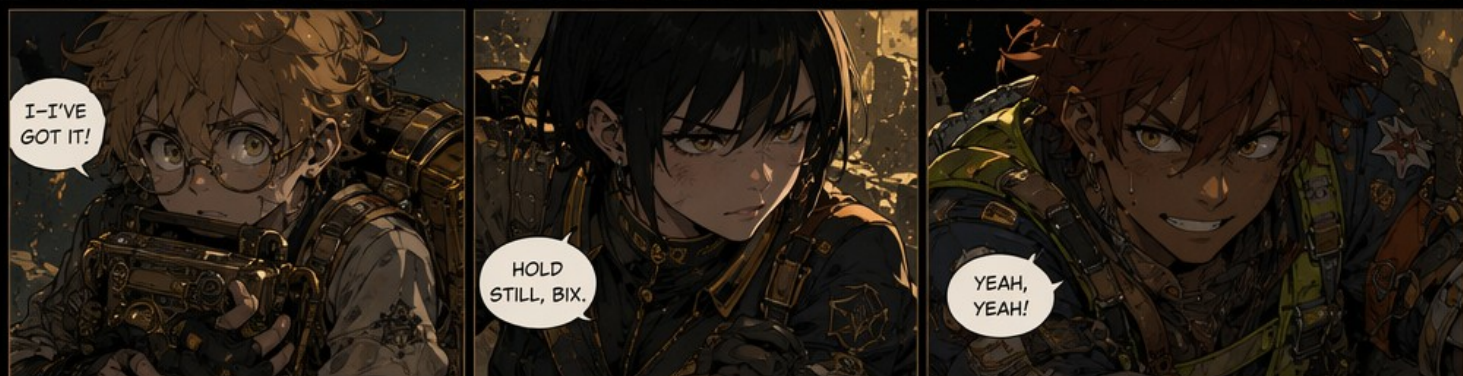
—as if
permanently
underwater.



I-I'VE
GOT IT!

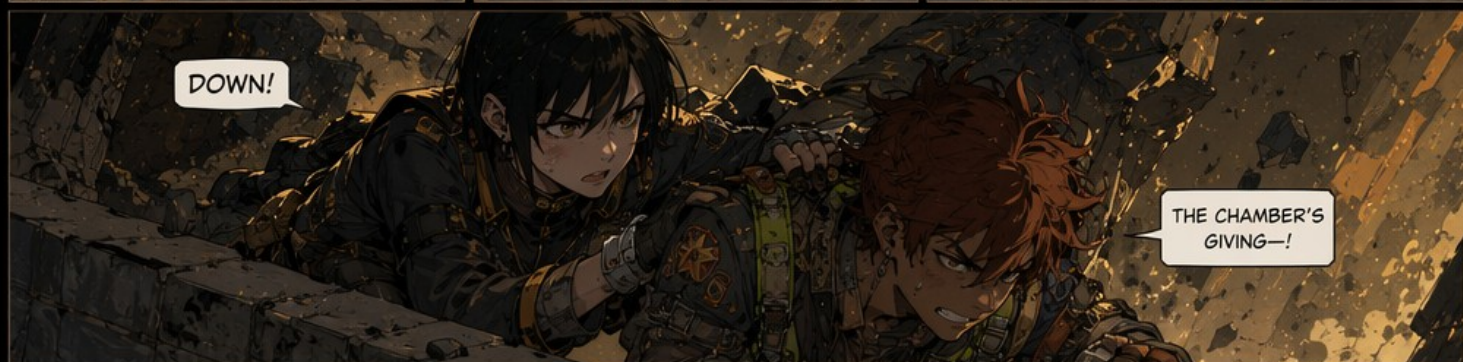
HOLD
STILL, BIX.

YEAH,
YEAH!



DOWN!

THE CHAMBER'S
GIVING—!



PRESSURE
SPIKING.

STRUCTURES
COMPROMISING.

SHE DOES
NOT HURRY.

SHE DOES
NOT NEED TO.



CHAMBER
OF THE
SOVEREIGN
DEPTHS

-3,907 FATHOMS

THE PRESSURE
HOLDS ALL
THINGS IN
ITS PATIENT
EMBRACE.

THIS WAY.
THERE'S A SIDE
PASSAGE.

MOVE CLOSE.

DON'T
LOOK BACK.

NOT UNTIL
WE'RE CLEAR.

RENN—

YOU SURE
WE'RE NOT
MISSING THE
GOOD PART?

FOCUS.

WE FOLLOW
ECHO.

WATCH YOUR
FOOTING.

THE STONE
SINGS UNDER
PRESSURE.

BEYOND THIS
NARROW PATH
THE PRESSURE
WILL EASE.

JUST FOR
THEM.

MOTHER
BATHYAL

DOES NOT
HURRY.

SHE SEES
ALL THINGS,
IN TIME.

HER ATTENTION
IS A CURRENT.

IT TURNS—
TO WHERE
IT IS MOST
NEEDED.

WHEN SHE TURNS,
THE PRESSURE
RELENTS.



MOTHER BATHYAL

YOU CANNOT
OUTWEAVE
THE OCEAN,
CHILD.

ONLY
BE DRAWN
DEEPER.

SHE DOES NOT HURRY.
THE ABYSS HAS
ALL THE TIME
IN THE WORLD.

I'VE BEEN
DEEP BEFORE.
I KNOW HOW
IT LOOKS AT
YOU.

BUT I'M NOT
SINKING.
NOT THIS
TIME.

THIS LINE
IS ALL THAT'S
LEFT BETWEEN
ME AND
THE FALL.

HOW
TENACIOUS.

HOW
...CURIOUS.

TENACITY IS A
BEAUTIFUL THING
IN SMALL
CREATURES.

IT MAKES
THE SURRENDER
SO MUCH
SWEETER.

I DON'T
SURRENDER.
I CLIMB.

EVEN IF THE
WALL IS THE
BOTTOM OF
THE WORLD.

I AM

KENN.

THE OCEAN REMEMBERS.
SO WILL I.





SLOANE.
SIXTEEN.

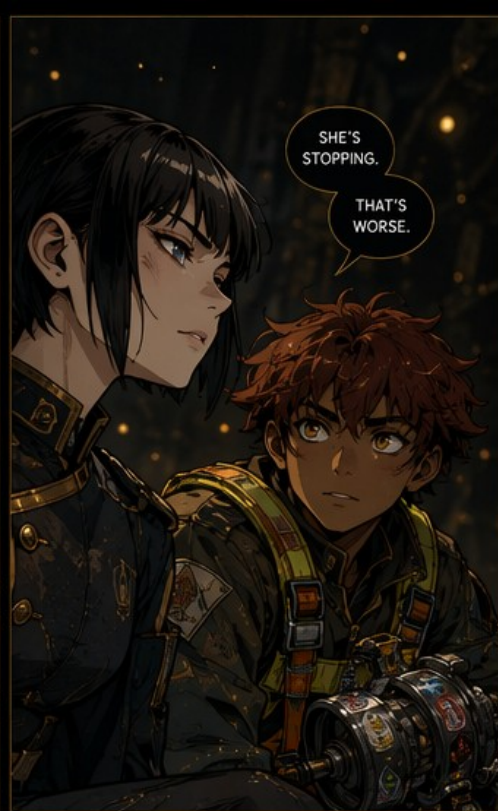
ANCHORITE VANGUARD CADET,
STRIPPED OF RANK.

DISCIPLINE IS HER BONES.
PRIDE, HER POSTURE.
FEAR, A PRIVILEGE
SHE DOES NOT INDULGE.

RENN.
SIXTEEN.

TENSION TECHNICIAN.
UNREGISTERED.

LUCKY. IMPUDENT.
ALIVE.
MAYBE.



SHE'S
STOPPING.

THAT'S
WORSE.



MOTHER BATHYAL.
SOVEREIGN OF THE
DROWNED DOMAINS.
SHE DOES NOT BREATHE.
SHE CIRCULATES.

ATMOSPHERE MADE
LIQUID GOLD.

PRESSURE MADE
WILL.



THE HAND
LOWERS.
THE CHAMBER
HOLDS ITS
BREATH.
THE MOMENT
STRETCHES.



HESITATION
BREAKS.
PRESSURE
EASES.
PRESENCE
REMAINS.
THE DEBT
IS NOT
CANCELLED.
ONLY
DEFERRED.



MOTHER BATHYAL HAS
SPOKEN.

HER WORDS
WILL ECHO LONG
AFTER SHE HAS
FALLEN SILENT.

YET EVEN NOW...
SHE TURNS
AWAY.



SHE CANNOT
MEAN IT.

NOT AFTER
ALL SHE HAS
REVEALED.



THIS IS
NOT OUR
WAY.

SHE LEAVES
US TO THE
TIDE'S
JUDGMENT?



SHE HEARS THEM
NOT.



THE WEIGHT SHE
CARRIES IS OLDER
THAN OBEDIENCE.

AND HEAVIER
THAN EVEN
THE ABYSS.

THE HEART OF THE SUNKEN CATHEDRAL.
DEPTH: 9,421 METERS.

...SHE
LET US GO.

HUH.

WELL, THAT
WASN'T IN THE
PLAN.

THERE IS NO
LOGICAL REASON
FOR HER MERCY.

D-DID WE
DO SOMETHING
RIGHT...?

PERHAPS.

OR PERHAPS
NOTHING AT ALL.

YOU CARRIED NO
HATRED INTO MY
DOMAIN.

THAT IS RARE.

YOU MAY LEAVE.

...WEIRD.

...UNSETTLING.

...I DON'T LIKE
IT.

...AS YOU
WISH.

THE TIDE REMEMBERS
THOSE WHO LISTEN.

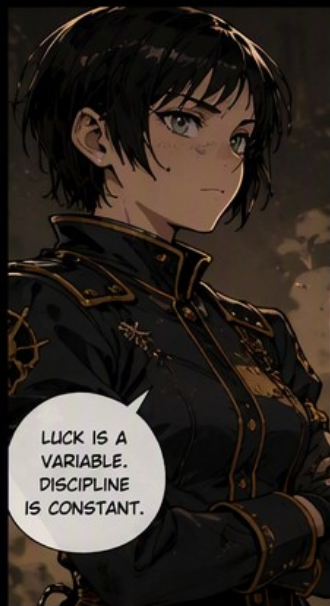
THE GOLDEN GLOOM
OUTER RIM, SECTOR 17
ANCHORITE WRECKAGE
- LEVELS BELOW



NO PURSUIT.
JUST DISTANCE.
AND LIGHT.



TOLDJA.
OLD GIRL'S
GOT LUCK.



LUCK IS A
VARIABLE.
DISCIPLINE
IS CONSTANT.



D-DID YOU
HEAR THAT
HISS? IS THAT
THE AIRLOCK?!



FOCUS.
BREATHE.
MOVE.
TOGETHER.



PACE: URGENT.
HEART: STEADY.
PLAN: SIMPLE.
GET HOME.



WELCOME
ABOARD THE
MANTA.

SAFE HARBOR
PROTOCOL
ENGAGED.

NOT SAFE.
BUT BETTER.
FOR NOW.

MANTA
INTERIOR DECK
MINUTES AFTER
THE FALL



YOU KNOW
WHAT'S CRAZY?

THE CONSOLE
FRAGMENT
SURVIVED THAT
BETTER THAN
ANY OF US
DID.

I MEAN... LOOK
AT THIS THING.



NO BRUISES.

NO FRACTURES.

NOT EVEN A
SCRATCH.

HONESTLY,
IT'S THE REAL
HERO HERE.

*INAUDIBLE
TICKING OF
ANXIETY*



BWA
HA
HA!



HA
HA
HA!



HA
HA
HA!



HAHAHAHAHA!!



VRRMMMMM
VVVRRMMMMM
VRMMMMMMMM

THE ENGINES
HUM BACK TO LIFE.

WE'RE STILL
IN ONE PIECE.

THAT'S ALL THAT
MATTERS, YEAH?



ANOTHER FALL SURVIVED.
ANOTHER STORY TO TELL.
TO BE CONTINUED...



MANTA

END OF EPISODE

"WE DON'T KNOW
WHAT WE'LL FIND.
BUT NOW WE KNOW
WHERE TO LOOK."

THE GLYPHS
ARE A MAP...
BUT NOT OF
A PLACE.

IT'S A
PATTERN.
A SEQUENCE.
A PATH.

CROSS-REFERENCING
WITH THE DIAGRAM FROM
THE ZENITH PLATES...

...THE FRAGMENTS
ALIGN. THE ANCHOR
POINTS CORRESPOND.

THE CONSOLE
WASN'T A TERMINAL.

IT WAS A KEY.

SO THE REAL
QUESTION IS...

WHAT DOES
IT UNLOCK?

...BEYOND THE
FINAL PLATE IS
THE CRADLE.

THE PLACE
WHERE THE
ANCHORS WERE
FORGED.

A PLACE LOST
BENEATH THE FIRST
FOUNDATION.

AND WHATEVER
POWERED THE
ANCHORS...

...STILL SLEEPS
THERE.

WE'VE COME
TOO FAR TO
TURN BACK.

YEAH.

LET'S SEE
WHAT WE
WERE BUILT
TO FIND.

THE ANCHORS
CHOOSE THEIR
WARDENS..

WE'LL PROVE
WE'RE WORTHY.

—◇ TO BE CONTINUED ◇—